NINJAS STEM FOUNDATION

Robotics Team Mentorship Policy

Independent-team support, student-centered responsibilities, and intake workflow

Policy ID	Approval status	Effective date
NSF-CP-02	Proposed; not adopted	To be established

1. Purpose, audience, and relationship to existing materials

This Policy consolidates the previously developed NSF Robotics Team Mentorship Program Policy & Overview for general use with independently operated youth robotics teams. It retains the program's student-centered approach, initial intake, separate mentorship plan, optional media permission, and session/progress log.

It provides educational support, not a guarantee of admission, competition success, funding, awards, intellectual-property rights, organizational membership, or affiliation. An independently mentored team remains separate unless a distinct, lawfully authorized onboarding arrangement expressly changes that relationship.

This harmonized draft does not replace any already adopted or contracted version merely by being published; confirm the existing program terms and Board approval status before use.

2. Program scope and eligibility

An independent team's Primary Coach or responsible adult may submit the standard Team Mentorship Intake Form identifying requested learning goals, experience, scheduling, student age group, location, supervision, and available resources. NSF may support VEX and other suitable robotics programs within its mission and mentor expertise.

NSF reviews requests consistently against educational fit, learning objectives, student-centered competition rules, availability of qualified mentors, safety arrangements, accessibility, expected time commitment, and available resources. An inquiry does not create a right to a mentoring placement.

3. Approval sequence and agreements

1. The participating team submits the standardized intake through its authorized adult contact.
2. An NSF Program Lead reviews readiness, program scope, supervision, availability and any required approval; the result is recorded.
3. If approved, both adult leads complete an Initial Mentorship Plan identifying period, venue, timing, goals, permitted assistance, responsibilities, and review point.
4. Both responsible adults confirm the plan before additional sessions are treated as committed. Separate financial or equipment support requires separate recorded approval.

4. Student-centered educational boundaries

NSF mentors may explain concepts, ask diagnostic questions, demonstrate general techniques, review student-created work, guide testing, and coach communication and problem solving. Mentored students design, construct, program, test, document and explain their own competition work and make their team's competition decisions.

Mentors shall not provide prohibited completed robot designs, code, notebooks, autonomous programs, or game strategy in place of students. Competition-specific rules and policies control the permissible assistance; the current organizer's policy should be checked for each program and season.

Students should maintain examples of their own design decisions, test results, debugging or documentation progress. NSF should evaluate growing independence and understanding rather than promise qualification or awards.

5. Responsibilities and safeguarding

NSF is responsible for supervising its mentors and complying with safeguarding duties it undertakes. The participating team's Primary Coach remains responsible for its team registration, parent permissions, student roster, supervision, conduct, and competition choices, except where a separate approved agreement expressly reallocates a particular responsibility.

Each in-person session shall have the responsible supervising adults identified in the plan and comply with applicable program, venue, and youth-protection requirements. Adult communications with minors must use appropriate approved channels; the adults coordinate scheduling directly.

Safety or safeguarding concerns may require postponement. Legally required reports shall not wait for a mentoring evaluation or Board meeting.

6. Frequency, location, cancellation, and rescheduling

The Initial Mentorship Plan establishes session frequency, duration, approved location and format. Locations may include an NSF-approved practice venue, the independent team's normal location, or an agreed virtual session, subject to suitable facilities, supervision, and any necessary permission.

When a session conflicts with a competition, illness, safety issue, or another scheduling constraint, the adult leads seek a mutually agreed replacement date. An alternative date is not confirmed until both sides agree; NSF does not guarantee a fixed number of sessions beyond an actual approved commitment.

7. Media, finances, property, and status

Identifiable child photographs, video, voice, names, or publicity require separate appropriate permission. Declining media permission does not affect mentoring eligibility. One organization's permission does not automatically authorize another independent team or sponsor to reuse a child's media.

Equipment loans, monetary grants, reimbursement, financial assistance, fundraising promises, and any organizational-affiliation change require independent approval and documentation. The team may not use NSF's bank accounts, EIN, donor acknowledgments or branding for independent fundraising without valid authorization. The intake and mentorship plan establish no fee unless a prospective fee is separately authorized and accurately disclosed.

8. Records, progress review, and end of engagement

The NSF mentor or Program Lead keeps a brief session record of date, duration, general attendance, concepts taught, student-produced work, next steps, and agreed action items. Identifiable student information remains in restricted records.

After approximately three sessions and again at the end of the stated term, adult leads discuss independent student progress and whether to continue, modify, pause, or end the arrangement. Either side may request a pause or stop; a renewal is separately confirmed and subject to resources and safeguarding.

Good-faith concerns may be raised through NSF's designated official channels, without limiting external reporting rights. Records are handled under the Privacy Statement and Records Retention & Access Policy.

9. Administrative package and review

Use the existing team-neutral documents: Team Mentorship Intake Form; Initial Mentorship Plan; optional parent/guardian photo/video permission; Session & Progress Log; and Internal Intake & Approval Checklist. The Board or authorized lead shall verify the current versions before implementation.

This Policy is prospective and does not determine any earlier mentoring agreement or disputed organizational status.